

neighbours CHINA

■ By Saurabh Shukla

Things are not all that quiet on the India-China border despite the laboured bonhomie between the two Asian powers. For the first time after the Sumdorong Chu incident in Arunachal Pradesh in 1987, which almost led to a war, a face-off on the western sector of the vexed boundary in Ladakh has sent shockwaves across the diplomatic and security establishments of the country.

Recently, a major confrontation with the People's Liberation Army (PLA) of China was averted by the timely intervention of senior officers from an

Indian patrol team. The incident took place on May 16 inside the Line of Actual Control (LAC) on the western sector of India-China boundary at Demchok, northeast of Ladakh. Insiders say PLA soldiers chased away Indian Intelligence Bureau (IB) personnel, who were verifying claims of Chinese intrusions near the Chardung-Nillung junction on the LAC. The IB team was accompanied by the army and Indo-Tibetan Border Police soldiers, who were closely engaged and followed by the Chinese patrols in three vehicles.

Chinese soldiers, say sources, even hurled abuses and shouted, "Indians go

back." They assumed position to fire at the Indians near the Chardung nullah. The Chinese then called another patrol party and chased the Indian groups. This border drama, which could have escalated into a clash with dangerous diplomatic consequences, unfolded at a time when the relationship between the two countries was passing through a 'blow hot, blow cold' phase.

The seriousness of this border skirmish can be judged from the fact that in 1967, it was an accidental firing at Nathula that led to a war between the two neighbours. "The Chinese provoked our soldiers. They even shouted at us, followed us, and then took posi-

BEIJING GAMES

DRAGON FIRE

Chinese troops engage Indian troops in a verbal duel and then take positions on the Line of Actual Control to fire at them

1 MAY 16, 2008, 08:30 A.M.

PLA troops confront a joint Indian patrol party of IB officials, the army and ITBP personnel on a mission to verify Chinese intrusion.

2 The provocation takes place at Demchok in the Ladakh region, well within Indian territory.

3 PLA troops chase away Indian troops and hurl abuses at them.

